

Primary Source Reading 2: The State of Nature

Optima Academy Online | Philosophy & Ethics | High School Honors (9–12) From Thomas Hobbes, Leviathan, Chapter XIII (1651) — text unaltered, original spelling preserved Read before Lesson 16b: The State of Nature

Before you read: This is the chapter that made Hobbes famous. He starts from a claim that surprised his readers — that human beings are naturally equal — and builds, step by step, to one of the bleakest and most quoted conclusions in political philosophy. As you read, track exactly how each step leads to the next: equality leads to hope, hope leads to competition, competition leads to war.

Natural Equality

Nature hath made men so equall, in the faculties of body, and mind; as that though there bee found one man sometimes manifestly stronger in body, or of quicker mind then another; yet when all is reckoned together, the difference between man, and man, is not so considerable, as that one man can thereupon claim to himselfe any benefit, to which another may not pretend, as well as he. For as to the strength of body, the weakest has strength enough to kill the strongest, either by secret machination, or by confederacy with others, that are in the same danger with himselfe.

From Equality Comes Hope, and From Hope, Enmity

From this equality of ability, ariseth equality of hope in the attaining of our Ends. And therefore if any two men desire the same thing, which neverthesse they cannot both enjoy, they become enemies; and in the way to their End, (which is principally their owne conservation, and sometimes their delectation only,) endeavour to destroy, or subdue one an other.

And from this diffidence of one another, there is no way for any man to secure himselfe, so reasonable, as Anticipation; that is, by force, or wiles, to master the persons of all men he can, so long, till he see no other power great enough to endanger him.

Three Causes of Quarrel

So that in the nature of man, we find three principall causes of quarrel. First, Competition; Secondly, Diffidence; Thirdly, Glory.

The first, maketh men invade for Gain; the second, for Safety; and the third, for Reputation. The first use Violence, to make themselves Masters of other mens persons, wives, children, and cattell; the second, to defend them; the third, for trifles, as a word, a smile, a different opinion, and any other signe of undervalue.

The War of Every Man Against Every Man

Hereby it is manifest, that during the time men live without a common Power to keep them all in awe, they are in that condition which is called Warre; and such a warre, as is of every man, against every man. For WARRE, consisteth not in Battell onely, or the act of fighting; but in a tract of time, wherein the Will to contend by Battell is sufficiently known... So the nature of War, consisteth not in actuall fighting; but in the known disposition thereto, during all the time there is no assurance to the contrary. All other time is PEACE.

In such condition, there is no place for Industry; because the fruit thereof is uncertain; and consequently no Culture of the Earth; no Navigation, nor use of the commodities that may be imported by Sea; no commodious Building... no Arts; no Letters; no Society; and which is worst of all, continuall feare, and danger of violent death; And the life of man, solitary, poore, nasty, brutish, and short.

After you read: Notice that Hobbes never says people are wicked. The word that does all the work in his argument is “security” — without it, even a person with no interest in harming anyone has every reason to strike first, because everyone else has the same reasoning available to them. As you read the lesson, consider whether this is a claim about human nature or a claim about incentives, and whether those turn out to be the same thing in Hobbes’s hands.